14.1.1 Understanding and managing environments

ASP.NET Core specifies three values to indicate the runtime environment of your application: `Production`, `Staging`, and `Development`. The framework reads an environment variable named `ASPNETCORE_ENVIRONMENT` to determine which value to apply to a running application. If the environment variable has not been set on the host machine, the value defaults to `Production`. This obviously works well on a hosting server, where you may not have access to set environment variables. In addition to the three built-in environments, ASP.NET Core allows you to use any string to represent an alternative environment name (e.g., *QA*).

When you run your application on your local machine using Visual Studio or the `dotnet run` command, the environment is set to `Development`. The application is launched using the first profile in the launchSettings.json file (in the Properties folder), which is considered the default profile. The following listing shows the first profile in my launchSettings.json file. Yours should look similar, although the port numbers in the `applicationUrl` node will probably differ. In any event, the `environmentVariables` section will be the same, setting `ASPNETCORE_ENVIRONMENT` to `Development`.

Listing 14.1 The first profile in launchSettings.json

```
"CityBreaks": {
  "commandName": "Project",
  "dotnetRunMessages": true,
  "launchBrowser": true,
  "applicationUrl": "https://localhost:7236;http://localhost:5236",
  "environmentVariables": {
    "ASPNETCORE_ENVIRONMENT": "Development"     ❶
  }
}
```